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Inside England's Bazball blueprint: Turning chasing into a strength

England has made fourth-innings chases a **core strategy** under Bazball, leading the world in successful run hunts since 2022. Here's how and why it works.

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For long, Test cricket never regarded chasing prowess as a strategy or a strength to rely on. It was something teams resorted to when pushed into a corner – an act born of necessity rather than preference.

But England, under the leadership of coach Brendon McCullum and captain Ben Stokes, has rewritten that age-old convention, laying down a bold new template for Test cricket.

Since 2022, the Three Lions, embracing a hyper-aggressive batting philosophy, have welcomed the challenge of chasing in

the fourth innings — and have reaped rich rewards.

England's latest fourth-innings conquest — a thrill-a-minute, final-day heist against India at Headingley in the opening Test — marked its seventh successful 200-plus chase in the Bazball era.

That's the most by any team in a four-year span in the history of Test cricket.

Tossing tradition

Right from the outset of McCullum's tenure, England has made clear its preference for chasing in Tests.

Stokes and McCullum's aggressive approach marks a sharp departure from

New template: England, under the leadership of coach Brendon McCullum and captain Ben Stokes, has embraced a hyper-aggressive batting philosophy. GETTY IMAGES

